



opposing fused  
toes give feet  
pincerlike grip

# Panther chameleon

*Furcifer pardalis*

independently  
moving eyes  
give almost  
360° view



## △ DAZZLING DISPLAY

Male panther chameleons are more colorful than females. They are at their brightest when competing with another male or courting a female, and least colorful when hunting.

The panther chameleon's impressive color changes are affected by its mood, such as when it is being aggressively territorial, dealing with a threat, or courting a mate. Temperature, humidity, light levels, and—to a lesser extent than popularly believed—matching the colors of its surroundings as a means of camouflage are also influencing factors.

An aid to recognizing coloration changes in other individuals is excellent eyesight, which is also important for capturing prey. The two turretlike eyes move independently to look in different directions simultaneously, or are both aimed at prey to judge its distance and motion. Then, the muscular, catapultlike tongue—which is longer than the chameleon's body—flicks out and back with the prey in just 0.007 seconds. Panther chameleons feed mostly on insects, such as

crickets and beetles, and spiders, but they will also eat small vertebrates such as frogs, baby lizards (including other chameleons), and rodents. They are active during the day, spending most of their time in low trees or bushes hunting for prey. At night, they sleep with their tail coiled tight around a thin branch.

## Ducking and bobbing

Panther chameleons live mostly alone and the males will display to, and even physically fight, others that intrude into their territory. However, during the breeding season (January–May), the aroused males—which are up to twice the size of the females—duck and bob to impress potential partners. The female lays up to six clutches of 10–50 eggs buried in moist soil, and the young hatch six to 12 months later.